

M E L V Y N P . L E F F L E R

A Preponderance of **POWER**

National Security,

the Truman Administration,

and the Cold War



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In Johnson's view, the only way to cut defense costs without undermining military capabilities was to strengthen the air/atomic component. Atomic weapons generated formidable striking power at relatively small cost compared with conventional weapons.⁵⁴

Webb and Lilienthal fumed at Johnson. Big, tough, and assertive, the defense secretary was not an easy man to sympathize with.⁵⁵ But his energies were absorbed and his patience taxed by the public brawl he was having with the Navy. In August 1949 the admirals revolted when they learned that the defense secretary was about to shave the Pentagon budget by another \$1 billion and that the Navy would bear the brunt of the reduction, a cut of almost \$400 million. Johnson, they charged, favored the Air Force, erred in procuring additional B-36 bombers, and engaged in personal favoritism in awarding contracts.⁵⁶ The admirals claimed that U.S. war plans depended too heavily on an atomic blitz. Strategic bombing, they argued, would not force the enemy to surrender. Even if the Russians did capitulate, the civilian losses caused by atomic attacks on enemy cities would be immoral, and postwar reconstruction everywhere would be endangered.⁵⁷

Johnson and Bradley were appalled by the admirals' accusations, many of which were voiced in open Senate hearings. They supported Francis P. Matthews, the new secretary of the Navy, when he fired Louis Denfeld, the chief of naval operations. Publicly, Johnson and Bradley sought to defend existing plans and procedures. The admirals' allegations, they insisted, distorted the importance of the B-36 in U.S. strategy and distracted attention from the balanced plans that had been decided on.⁵⁸ Privately, they continued to grapple with irreconcilable pressures. At one and the same time, they struggled to comply with the president's \$13 billion budget ceiling and to formulate an integrated defense plan that met Allied demands for a defense on the Rhine. With limited funds, they attempted to match capabilities with the strategic undertakings of their war plans and with the diplomatic commitments of the State Department. In the short run, the strategic offensive, as the admirals argued, might not be able to prevent Soviet armies from overrunning Europe. But Johnson and Bradley assumed that, as the nation's air and atomic capabilities further improved and as European nations enhanced their own conventional capabilities, the Rhine would be defended. Confidentially, the Joint Chiefs of Staff (JCS) maintained that their request for an accelerated atomic weapons program stemmed from their realization that newly designed bombs could be used economically in lieu of conventional weapons to thwart the advance of Soviet forces. Army planners looked upon tactical atomic weapons as a key instrument for breaking up Soviet troop concentrations and seizing critical areas. With more and better atomic weapons, Western Europe might be held.⁵⁹

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Until autumn 1949, much of this discussion was of abstract importance. Officials were convinced that war was unlikely so long as the United States possessed an

atomic monopoly. The bomb, in fact, served as more than a deterrent to unprovoked Russian aggression; it constituted a shield behind which the nation could pursue its diplomatic goals. So long as the Russian sphere was not directly challenged, State Department officials assumed that the Soviets would back down rather than allow a diplomatic crisis to come to a test of arms. U.S. officials, therefore, possessed the confidence to do things they might otherwise have hesitated to do if they suspected that their actions could trigger a sequence of moves that might lead to war.⁶⁰

Then suddenly the monopoly was over. In September 1949 U.S. intelligence sources picked up traces of radioactivity over the northern Pacific and, after several weeks, concluded that the Soviets had detonated an atomic device. Truman hesitated a while before making the announcement. He feared that it would profoundly disturb the peoples of Western Europe and the United States. After a few days of bold headlines and alarmist stories, however, the public seemed to adjust. Only 5 percent of Americans said the control of atomic weapons was the most important problem facing the country. Officials were surprised by the calm reaction of people at home and abroad.⁶¹

In fact, U.S. policymakers were far more agitated than were the American people. Officials had known that the Soviets would soon possess the bomb. Acheson had been saying that the Kremlin would acquire atomic capabilities in mid-1950 or 1951. But the reality was shocking. U.S. officials did not fear any immediate changes in the military balance of power, but the political and psychological implications appeared enormous, coming precisely when the British were devaluing the pound and reassessing their own global capabilities.⁶²

Policymakers had to rethink the place of atomic weapons in U.S. foreign and military policies. If atomic weapons had been vital to U.S. war plans, Pentagon officials would now have to reassess their strategy in light of the expectation that the Soviets would someday be able to retaliate. If the value of atomic weapons were diminished by the fact that adversaries now possessed them, it would be incumbent upon U.S. officials to reappraise their approach to the international control of atomic energy. And, most important, if atomic weapons had been central to deterrence and diplomatic risk-taking, policymakers at Foggy Bottom would have to rethink the diplomatic implications of the Soviet acquisition of atomic capabilities.⁶³ If Europeans concluded that the United States would not risk atomic retaliation for the defense of Europe, would they proceed with measures to integrate West Germany into Western Europe? Would they go ahead with plans to build up their military capabilities, plans that they knew the Kremlin opposed? If heretofore they had assumed that the Kremlin was deterred by the U.S. atomic monopoly, would they now choose to forgo integration and military rearmament and avoid the attendant risks? Would they seek diplomatic accommodation rather than risk diplomatic crisis and possible war? And if war came, how indeed would the United States defend Europe if, in fact, it were unwilling to use nuclear weapons and risk atomic retaliation?

At meetings with Acheson and with the Policy Planning Staff, the State Depart-

ment's top officials concluded that these matters merited extremely careful study. Webb worried that countries as far away from the United States as Afghanistan might be affected by the diplomatic shadows cast by the Soviet atomic explosion. Dean Rusk felt that U.S. strategic plans now had to be reexamined. Indeed, the nation's entire foreign policy posture required a reappraisal. It was time to rethink the conclusions of NSC 20/4, ponder whether rearmament should receive greater priority than economic assistance, study whether conventional or atomic weapons should be relied on for warmaking purposes, and assess whether containment across the Eurasian land mass was desirable and practical. Rusk said he would begin exploring these matters, and Acheson agreed to broach the matter with the president.⁶⁴

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The Truman administration now approved the JCS request to accelerate the atomic energy program. On 10 October, Johnson, Acheson, and Lilienthal submitted their report to the president. The secretary of defense reiterated the cost effectiveness of atomic weapons. New and smaller atomic weapons would decrease the logistical and personnel requirements for certain military tasks. Although Johnson made clear that his recommendations were not directly related to the recent Soviet atomic breakthrough, he stressed that the nation now needed enough weapons to attack atomic targets in the Soviet Union as well as to fulfill the strategic undertakings already enumerated in U.S. war plans. Johnson emphasized that "when the USSR attains a stockpile of atomic weapons, overwhelming superiority of our stockpile and production rate will be necessary if our atomic weapon posture is to continue to act as a deterrent to war." Acheson agreed. Lilienthal, unhappy with the report, nevertheless acknowledged that the accelerated program was feasible, provided agreement could be reached with the United Kingdom and Canada. Truman quickly approved the subcommittee's findings. He would ask Congress to appropriate the funds during the next fiscal year.⁶⁵

The October decision was a particularly important one for the president. It set the pattern for his support of the hydrogen bomb. As soon as news of the Soviet atomic explosion became known, champions of thermonuclear weapons stepped up their demands for money and personnel. The possibility of developing a hydrogen bomb had been discussed since the end of World War II but had not been assigned a high priority. Nevertheless, several leading scientists, including Ernest Lawrence, Edward Teller, and Luis W. Alvarez, were extremely interested in it. So were members of the Military Liaison Committee that served as the conduit between the JCS and the AEC. And in the latter agency, Commissioner Lewis L. Strauss was also a proponent of thermonuclear weapons.⁶⁶

The appeal of a bomb based on the fusion process, a super bomb as many called it, tantalized some scientists and many military planners. For the former, the hydrogen bomb constituted a new outlet for creative talents; for the latter, weapons a hundred times more powerful than the Hiroshima bomb were irresistible. Posses-

sion of such a bomb by the United States would instantly restore its superiority. On the other hand, if the Soviets developed it, the global balance of power would be transformed. The men at the Pentagon were not alone in such thinking. Paul Nitze talked to Teller and Lawrence and learned that, in their scientific opinion, the Soviets could indeed be working on the hydrogen bomb. If this were the case and if, in fact, thermonuclear weapons could be developed, the United States had to enter the race. For if the Soviets alone had the hydrogen bomb, the psychological fallout in peacetime would be enormous. They would assume risks they had heretofore eschewed; they would capitalize on revolutionary unrest and social dislocation. According to Nitze, they “might dominate the world.”⁶⁷

A major policy review ensued, a review that has received excellent treatment by other historians. Lilienthal, a majority of the commissioners on the AEC, and all the prominent scientists on the General Advisory Committee to the AEC opposed development of a thermonuclear weapon. They contended that it was an immoral, genocidal weapon. Moreover, there was no need for it. An expanded atomic arsenal could achieve the same goals. Atomic weapons would deter the Soviets from an attack even if they possessed the hydrogen bomb. Pursuit of thermonuclear weapons would only encourage the Soviets to emulate the U.S. effort, triggering an arms race of unprecedented dimensions.⁶⁸

Johnson, the JCS, and Strauss disagreed. The United States had to try to develop the hydrogen bomb. In wartime, thermonuclear weapons could be used profitably against large concentrations of enemy troops and against the adversary’s atomic air bases. Moreover, they could prove cost effective because of their tremendous striking power. Fewer bombs would be necessary; fewer crews would have to be trained; fewer planes would be required for their delivery. But the JCS clearly thought that the psychological advantages of the hydrogen bomb outweighed its military usefulness. If the Soviets had the super bomb, it

would have grave psychological and political repercussions . . . among the nations of the Western world. . . . It would provide the Soviet leaders, people, and satellites with a tremendous psychological boost which in peacetime could lead to increased truculence in international affairs and increased political infiltration in nations of the western world. The tremendous “blackmail” potential of the thermonuclear weapon would serve the USSR well in its aims to impose its will upon the nations of Europe and to alienate these nations from the Western camp.

Knowing how important the atomic monopoly had been to U.S. diplomatic strategy and war plans, the JCS dreaded the prospective impact of thermonuclear weapons on Soviet risk-taking.⁶⁹

These arguments drew support in the State Department. Yet Acheson initially etched out a position of neutrality between the Defense Department and the AEC. When Truman reappointed the three-man committee to advise him on whether or not to go ahead with the super bomb, Acheson stressed that he would not be hurried into a decision. He thought work on the super bomb might intensify anxieties around

the world and set back economic recovery. He wanted Kennan to have the time to make his case against atomic weapons. Yet Acheson repeatedly pointed out that a no-first-use policy might undermine U.S. deterrence and hurt diplomacy.⁷⁰

Kennan poured all his energies into convincing his colleagues to abandon their reliance on atomic weapons and settle for an imperfect system of international control. He knew his influence was waning. He would make one last concerted effort to persuade Acheson that atomic weapons were not necessary for deterrence or for war. The reliance on atomic weapons, he said, distorted clear thinking about the nature of the threat and the best means to cope with it. The contest with the Kremlin was political. Without international control, there would be a psychological penchant to use atomic weapons. But the destruction would be out of all proportion to the ends desired. Kennan preferred to rely on a few well-prepared and highly mobile divisions to implement foreign policy. He was thinking in terms of limited war and not of full-scale conflict with the Kremlin.

Kennan's position on atomic weapons was inextricably linked to his diplomatic goals. Believing that European conventional capabilities could be built up to constitute an appropriate deterrent, he argued that the conventional superiority of Soviet armies was an artifact of the war, a product of the vacuum of power in Central Europe. The most important task was to get the Kremlin out of Eastern Europe and to co-opt German strength for the West. If an agreement could be reached that would disengage the Soviets from Eastern Europe and if the rest of Europe were integrated into a third force, then a viable conventional balance could be created on the European continent. Accordingly, he opposed including Great Britain in a prospective European continental union because he thought it would accentuate the difficulties of attracting Eastern Europe into it. But if this new configuration of power could be created and if some system of international control could be devised, the world would be a much safer place, and U.S. security would be enhanced far more than it would be through a nuclear arms race. A defense posture that had atomic weapons at its core, Kennan concluded, made no sense. In wartime, their use would be disastrous; in peacetime, their presence would complicate relations with friends and foes.⁷¹

From September 1949 through January 1950, Kennan's views received a fair hearing at the State Department. Although few of his colleagues were inclined to think in terms of a third force, many of his other ideas were looked upon sympathetically. Acheson shared Kennan's desire to build up European conventional strength, drive a wedge into the Kremlin's sphere of influence, and lure East European governments westward. Yet atomic superiority, far from undermining the nation's diplomacy as Kennan seemed to be arguing, appeared to be an indispensable asset.⁷²

Acheson gravitated toward the ideas of Nitze. Yet it must be emphasized that neither Acheson nor Nitze differed with Kennan on the nature of the Soviet threat. They differed with him primarily on the role of atomic weapons in U.S. diplomacy. The military threat, Nitze insisted, was a tertiary one. The United States

was locked in a cold war with the Kremlin, and the nature of the conflict was not likely to change. Soviet leaders, Acheson and Nitze maintained, “need and want the people, industry and resources of Western Europe. . . . Success in the cold war achieves these. The hot war may lose all this and more too.” The supreme task was to develop a defense posture that would thwart Soviet peacetime efforts to gain control over critical resources, industrial infrastructure, and skilled labor. “This is important,” Acheson noted in the most significant memorandum dealing with the hydrogen bomb: “The loss of Western Europe or of important parts of Asia or the Middle East would be a transfer of potential from West to East, which, depending on the area, might have the gravest consequences in the long run.”⁷³

Soviet atomic weapons, most State Department officials believed, enhanced the Kremlin’s penchant for risk-taking. The Russians were more rash, more willing to take chances, more supportive of revolutionary movements around the world. Nitze compiled an exhaustive list of recent Soviet moves and concluded that their actions bordered on recklessness, especially as they endangered the power position of the United States. “Nothing about the moves indicates that Moscow is preparing to launch in the near future an all-out military attack on the West. They do, however, suggest a greater willingness than in the past to undertake a course of action, including a possible use of force in local areas, which might lead to an accidental outbreak of general military conflict. Thus the chance of war through miscalculation is increased.”⁷⁴

If the Soviets should also develop the hydrogen bomb, they would be further emboldened. They would not want war but they would take risks and seek gains that they had heretofore not dared to contemplate. There was no immediate military threat because the Soviets were not believed to have a significant stockpile of atomic weapons or any real delivery capabilities. But in five to ten years, the Soviet stockpile might be of sufficient size to neutralize the U.S. atomic deterrent. What then would substitute for this deterrent in peacetime and for this capability in war-time? It seemed as if Europe’s conventional capabilities would have to be increased and the U.S. atomic arsenal enlarged still further. But these matters were infinitely complex, and Nitze urged Acheson to undertake the comprehensive review of the nation’s diplomatic and strategic posture that had been contemplated since October. Meanwhile, Nitze argued that prudence demanded that the United States proceed to develop its own super bomb. The program need not be a crash program, but it should be undertaken.⁷⁵

When Acheson met with Johnson and Lilienthal on 31 January 1950, his mind was made up. Well aware that the president was inclined to move ahead, Acheson recognized the substantial political pressures that demanded action. Senator McMahon was pressing for the project, as were prominent Republicans who were now more enraged than ever by Acheson’s refusal to disavow Alger Hiss after the latter’s recent conviction for perjury. Public opinion polls in January and February overwhelmingly supported the effort to build a hydrogen bomb. Although these

considerations did not prompt Lilienthal to alter his opposition to thermonuclear weapons, they reinforced the geopolitical and diplomatic influences already impelling Acheson to move in this direction.⁷⁶

In their brief meeting with the president, Acheson and Johnson urged that the United States proceed to determine the technological feasibility of a thermonuclear weapon and that concurrent work should be undertaken on ordnance development and on a carrier program. Although Acheson and Johnson acknowledged that the Soviets probably preferred to wage a cold war and that even if the Soviets possessed the super bomb they might not use it, the United States could not take such a risk. “Sole possession by the Soviet Union of this weapon would cause severe damage not only to our military posture but to our foreign policy position.” The president agreed. If the Russians could do it, so must the Americans.⁷⁷

At a time when the international situation still seemed fluid and the accomplishments in Europe ephemeral, U.S. officials rebelled at the thought of losing superiority in atomic weapons. They did not want to forfeit the psychological edge that inspired them to take risks and afforded them significant advantages in waging the cold war. If they had to ponder the possibility that the atomic power of the Soviet Union might prevail in a conflict or neutralize their own atomic arsenal, their diplomacy might become more cautious. They assumed that, if the men in the Kremlin thought U.S. officials might hesitate to act in a crisis, lest it escalate into a global conflict, Russian diplomacy would become more aggressive. The Soviets’ inclination to use force in local areas would increase, their penchant to challenge the West in its traditional spheres of influence would mount, their temptation to thwart integration efforts in Western Europe would grow, and their efforts either to intimidate or to lure Western Germany eastward would intensify. It was believed that, heretofore, America’s atomic monopoly had modulated Soviet risk-taking and had enabled the United States to proceed with the establishment of a configuration of power compatible with U.S. interests. If this advantage disappeared, the cold war might be lost.

Considerations of this sort, not domestic political or exclusively military ones, drove U.S. officials into an arms race. Public opinion proved to be malleable. In February and March, American attitudes swiftly changed. The historian Barton Bernstein has shown that, once prominent senators like McMahon and Millard Tydings changed their minds and called for a renewed peace effort, the majority of Americans agreed that the government should make another attempt at the international control of atomic energy before proceeding with the development of thermonuclear weapons. But Truman and his advisers were no longer interested in international control.⁷⁸

Instead, after the British arrested Klaus Fuchs as a Soviet spy, the U.S. government decided to accelerate work on the hydrogen bomb. Fuchs had worked on the Manhattan Project and had been deeply involved in postwar atomic research. Officials feared that the Soviets might be farther along the road to a hydrogen bomb

than they had previously assumed. Major General Kenneth D. Nichols and Brigadier General Herbert B. Loper of the Military Liaison Committee, in fact, taking a worst-case scenario, warned Johnson that the Soviets might have been working on thermonuclear weapons since 1945 and that these bombs might already be in production. The Russians' stockpile of atomic weapons might be equal to or superior to that of the United States. Johnson pressured the president to authorize a crash program "if we are not to be placed in a potentially disastrous position." Swayed by this warning, Truman ordered an acceleration of the hydrogen bomb project.⁷⁹

Once again, it is essential to emphasize that U.S. officials were not worrying about purposeful Soviet military aggression. They were worried about the diplomatic shadows cast by strategic power. In the months following the detection of the atomic explosion in the Soviet Union, analysts in the State Department, AEC, CIA, JCS, Navy, Army, and Air Force invested enormous effort in estimating Soviet atomic capabilities and their impact on Soviet goals, tactics, and behavior. The information was sketchy and there was considerable discord over some details, but only the Air Force thought the Kremlin might be tempted into an outright attack on the United States. The consensus was that real danger would emerge in the mid-1950's. And even then the danger rested not so much on the likelihood of a Soviet preemptive attack on the United States as on the possibility of a war arising from miscalculation as the Soviets reacted to U.S. efforts to establish situations of strength in Europe and Asia and as they supported insurrectionary movements in the Third World.

Soviet atomic capabilities, the intelligence analysts concurred, made the world a much more dangerous place. They estimated that the Kremlin would have 10–20 atomic bombs in mid-1950, 25–45 a year later, 45–90 in mid-1952, and 120–200 by mid-1954. Not knowing the accuracy of Soviet weapons and delivery vehicles, the analysts squabbled over the percentage of bombs that were likely to be dropped on target. But there was no doubt that, as the Soviets built up their capabilities, the U.S. capacity to strike the Soviet Union without fear of retaliation would end. Moreover, U.S. bases in the United Kingdom would be increasingly at risk, and the United States would have to devote a much greater percentage of its budget to defensive weaponry. And once the Soviets could deliver about 200 bombs to their targets in the United States, a development that was thought likely to occur in the late 1950's, it was believed that America's industrial infrastructure could be dealt a crippling blow and its ability to wage a prolonged war might be jeopardized. U.S. officials would then have to ponder whether or not to risk a nuclear war.

The Kremlin, analysts were certain, would capitalize on these doubts. According to the Joint Intelligence Committee of the JCS, the Soviets would exploit fully the opportunity to erode the influence of the Western powers throughout the world. Thinking that the Americans might back down rather than risk nuclear war, the Russians might interfere in Berlin, promote German unification, support political seizures of power in Greece, Italy, or France, encourage the Chinese to give aid

to Ho Chi Minh, or interfere with the negotiation of a Japanese peace treaty. The Soviets might demand a role in the Ruhr, object to the lifting of the remaining controls over West Germany, or insist on their right to reinsert troops into Japan. Even if the United States were not bullied by such actions, the intelligence agencies agreed that America's allies might "refrain from joining this country in taking a more positive political position against the USSR."⁸⁰

Analysts also believed that, in undertaking these types of initiatives, the Kremlin might precipitate war. The United States, of course, could choose to back down or escalate the crisis. If it backed down, its efforts to thwart Soviet preponderance would be undermined. If it escalated the crisis, the country would be subject to atomic attack if war should erupt. The dilemmas were excruciating. For good reason, therefore, Truman endorsed Acheson's desire to conduct a wide-ranging analysis of the nation's goals in light of Soviet atomic and prospective thermonuclear capabilities.⁸¹ But before the study could be completed, problems at home and abroad would worsen still further.

The Fate of Asia

In autumn 1949, the Chinese Communists consolidated their hold in the south and southwest of China and drove the remnants of Nationalist troops into Burma and across the straits to Taiwan. In October, Mao Tse-tung established the People's Republic of China and requested foreign governments to establish formal diplomatic relations. For all intents and purposes the civil war on the mainland was over; the Communists had triumphed.

Observing the ominous trend of events, Johnson again asked Acheson to join in a comprehensive study of U.S. policy toward Asia. Acheson's assistants resented Johnson's intrusion into their bureaucratic domain. They sneered at NSC 48, the initial paper produced by the NSC staff. Instead, the Far East experts in the State Department collaborated with Philip Jessup and the two outside Republican consultants, Everett Case and Raymond Fosdick, whom Acheson had chosen to review the administration's Asian policy. Since the *White Paper* had failed to quell the accusations of the China bloc, Acheson hoped that soliciting Republican input might resuscitate bipartisanship. Although renowned for his emphasis on European priorities, Acheson nevertheless deemed Asian problems to be among his foremost concerns.⁸²

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Virtually everyone concurred in the autumn of 1949 that Japan was the most important country in Asia. Japan's significance lay in its latent manufacturing potential and trained work force. Were "Japan added to the Communist bloc," Acheson informed British ambassador Oliver Franks, "the Soviets would acquire skilled manpower and industrial potential capable of significantly altering the balance of

prevent the domination of Formosa by a Communist power.” MacArthur requested permission to assess the military assistance that would be required “to hold Formosa against attack.”¹⁸²

Significantly, Truman and Acheson did not stop the study. Acheson’s China experts and CIA intelligence analysts had become disheartened by the alleged rapid consolidation of Soviet influence on the mainland. They were less certain than ever of a Sino-Soviet split.¹⁸³ Oliver Franks, the British ambassador and Acheson’s close friend, reported to his government that the secretary of state’s views were in flux. Truman’s and Acheson’s contempt for Chiang Kai-shek remained unchanged. Their intent was not to salvage his regime; instead, they were now thinking of ways to deny Taiwan to Communist China. Rusk talked about trusteeship and MacArthur ruminated about transferring power to the Taiwanese. Truman liked the notion of saving China without Chiang. Moreover, both he and Acheson agreed that some dramatic initiative was imperative to restore U.S. morale and undermine the appeal of McCarthyism.¹⁸⁴

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The diplomatic offensive that was contemplated in the spring of 1950 was of enormous scope. Around the Eurasian land mass, U.S. officials hoped to regain the initiative by strengthening NATO, co-opting the power of West Germany, continuing aid after 1952, deploying additional troops to Europe, expanding military assistance to the Near East and Southeast Asia, inaugurating new programs of economic aid in the underdeveloped world, launching covert operations in the general area of China, negotiating a Japanese peace treaty, neutralizing Taiwan, and forming a Pacific alliance. But offensive diplomacy was infused with risk-taking, and risk-taking required military muscle to back it up.

NSC 68 and the Continuity of U.S. Foreign Policy

Throughout the spring of 1950, Paul Nitze devoted his time to writing the report on the impact of Soviet atomic capabilities on U.S. foreign policy goals and tactics. He conferred with prominent scientists like Robert Oppenheimer and with former officials like Robert Lovett. He coordinated his efforts with General Burns and other representatives from the Pentagon. But NSC 68 was the creation of Nitze and the Policy Planning Staff, which he now directed.¹⁸⁵

Despite its hyperbolic rhetoric, NSC 68 essentially reaffirmed the assumptions that had been driving U.S. foreign policy during the Truman administration. The Soviets were animated by a “new fanatic faith, antithetical to our own.” In the long run they wanted to impose their “absolute authority over the rest of the world.” In the immediate future they hoped to establish “domination of the Eurasian land mass.” U.S. national security was imperiled because “any substantial further ex-

tension of the area under the domination of the Kremlin would raise the possibility that no coalition adequate to confront the Kremlin with greater strength could be assembled.”¹⁸⁶

NSC 68, moreover, explicitly endorsed the goals that had been enumerated in NSC 20/4 of November 1948. U.S. aims, however, were not limited to deterring war, containing Soviet expansion, and thwarting internal subversion. Nitze stressed that U.S. goals were designed to reduce Soviet power on its periphery, establish independent countries in Eastern Europe, revive nationalist aspirations among subject peoples within the Soviet Union, and “foster a fundamental change in the nature of the Soviet system, a change toward which the frustration of the design is the first and perhaps most important task.”¹⁸⁷ Although some historians have suggested that these aims diverged from earlier objectives, these goals had been frequently espoused by U.S. officials. Since the onset of the Truman administration, the object of U.S. policy had been to thwart the Kremlin’s ability to gain global preponderance through its own efforts or through the machinations of its Communist allies. But once the Communists were contained, U.S. officials sought to link the power centers of Europe and Asia within an American-led orbit. From this position, the United States hoped to dislodge the Kremlin from Eastern Europe and pave the way for transformation of the system of government within Soviet Russia.¹⁸⁸

Furthermore, every program alluded to in NSC 68 either had been or was in the process of being launched. Nitze called for economic assistance, military aid, covert operations, psychological warfare, and solutions to the dollar gap. He referred to the need to improve internal security and to enhance intelligence activities. He enumerated the strategic undertakings that had been laid out in dozens of war-plan exercises.¹⁸⁹

What was new about NSC 68 was that Nitze simply called for more, more, and more money to implement the programs and to achieve the goals already set out. He envisioned higher taxes, and he thought that domestic social and welfare programs might have to be curtailed. Most important, he emphasized the need to build up U.S. military capabilities. More arms were needed to implement strategic undertakings; more arms were needed for military assistance; more arms were needed to support U.S. foreign policy and “to defeat local Soviet moves with local action.” It was this emphasis on military means that so upset Kennan.¹⁹⁰

Nitze called for a new stress on military hardware because he believed that by the mid-1950’s Soviet atomic capabilities would greatly enhance Soviet risk-taking, discourage U.S. initiative, and intimidate allies. NSC 68 sought to demonstrate that the Soviets were achieving unprecedented military capabilities by allocating disproportionate amounts of the gross national product to heavy industry and arms production. The sections of the report that stressed the magnitude of the Kremlin’s arms buildup received much criticism from insiders. But Nitze’s key points were not disputed: the Soviets did possess a superiority in conventional arms, and they would

be able to develop an arsenal of perhaps 200 atomic bombs by the mid-1950's.¹⁹¹

The real significance of these facts was *not* that the Soviets would engage in premeditated military aggression or launch an atomic assault against the United States. Nitze acknowledged that such scenarios were tertiary threats and unlikely.¹⁹² Instead, the significance was that Soviet atomic capabilities might neutralize the diplomatic shadows heretofore cast by the U.S. atomic monopoly. Enemies and allies would both doubt U.S. willingness to risk nuclear war over limited issues; hence the United States would no longer have the means to encourage allies or to intimidate foes. Knowing this, the Soviets might show diplomatic boldness, augment their support for internal subversion, and foment local aggression. Their excessive strength, argued NSC 68, “provides the Soviet Union with great coercive power for use in time of peace in furtherance of its objectives and serves as a deterrent to the victims of its aggression from taking any action in opposition to its tactics which would risk war.”¹⁹³

U.S. officials must not equivocate or vacillate for fear of provoking the Soviets and precipitating global war, Nitze believed. Given the setbacks of late 1949, the temptation of the Soviets to engage in new forms of risk-taking, and the erosion of European influence in the Middle East and Asia, the United States had to do what was necessary to achieve its objectives. U.S. foreign policy “requires the free world to develop a successfully functioning political and economic system and a vigorous political offensive against the Soviet Union.” The United States had to sign a peace treaty with Japan, link West Germany to NATO, preserve stability in the Middle East, and thwart the spread of communism in Southeast Asia. Initiatives of this sort required “an adequate military shield under which they can develop.” “Without superior aggregate military strength, in being and readily mobilizeable, a policy of containment—which is in effect a policy of calculated and gradual coercion—is no more than a policy of bluff.”¹⁹⁴

U.S. diplomacy was imbued with an offensive spirit. In the worldview of NSC 68, there was no room for neutrality; diplomacy was a zero-sum game. The stakes were global preponderance. The risks were great. Nitze grasped it well: “Only if we had overwhelming atomic superiority and obtained command of the air might the U.S.S.R. be deterred from employing its atomic weapons *as we progressed toward the fulfillment of our objectives*.”¹⁹⁵

Precisely because the goals, assumptions, and arguments of NSC 68 were not new and because he placed no price tags on the programs, Nitze was able to elicit a great deal of support. Bohlen thought Nitze exaggerated Soviet intentions; Willard Thorp, head of economic affairs at the State Department, believed he overestimated Soviet economic capabilities; George Perkins, head of European affairs, and Llewellyn Thompson, his key assistant, suggested that Nitze underrated the potential efficacy of existing measures.¹⁹⁶ But NSC 68 was perfectly compatible with the thinking that infused all the State Department papers on Europe, the Middle East,

and Southeast Asia in April and May 1950. Acheson, therefore, had no trouble accepting NSC 68. The thrust of the report, as Bohlen noted, was “unchallengeable.”¹⁹⁷

Defense Secretary Johnson was initially infuriated by his inadequate knowledge about the development of NSC 68. He regarded it as another effort by Acheson to circumvent normal policymaking channels, demean the Defense Department, embarrass his own cost-cutting efforts, and enhance Foggy Bottom’s control of national security policy. But Nitze discreetly approached the JCS and got the chiefs to bring Johnson around. If the defense secretary had known that Nitze was thinking of tripling military spending, he would never have agreed. But hardly anyone in the Pentagon contemplated increments of this magnitude. There was no reason to oppose NSC 68, for it was obvious to everyone in official circles that U.S. policy had to be firmed up. The real issues were defining how much more should be spent on defense, how rapidly, and in what ways.¹⁹⁸

Truman read NSC 68 and asked the NSC to provide him with additional information on costs and implications. An NSC ad hoc group was set up to undertake this work. It proceeded in a desultory fashion. The sums envisioned did not approach what Nitze wanted. The Budget Bureau strongly opposed large increments. The JCS equivocated. Voorhees still believed that substantial savings could be made by integrating military and economic aid. Defense planning for the next fiscal year continued on the basis of a constricted budget. In early June, Nitze grew frustrated. On 7 June he left for vacation.¹⁹⁹

Top State Department officials appeared ready to raise taxes, cut domestic programs, increase imports, and accept budget deficits in pursuit of national security goals. Truman displayed no such disposition. In a series of speeches and press conferences in May and June, he passed up opportunity after opportunity to make a case for large increments in military expenditures. Yet at the same time he reaffirmed U.S. goals and supported existing policies, including the options contemplated in the spring reassessment of 1950. He hoped to achieve preponderance on the cheap.²⁰⁰

The hesitation in part emanated from the character of the threat. The Soviets now had the bomb, but hardly anyone of influence in Washington, Paris, or London expected the Kremlin to engage in overt aggression.²⁰¹ Bohlen told Nitze that he needed to do a better job substantiating his claim that the gap between Soviet and U.S. military capabilities was widening; others doubted that it was widening. The Joint Intelligence Committee at the U.S. embassy in Moscow concluded that net relative military capabilities of the Soviet bloc and the free world had changed but slightly, *and in favor of the West*, during the preceding year.²⁰² Moreover, there was considerable opinion in defense circles that Europe could be defended without anything resembling the increments in defense expenditures that Nitze had in mind. Bush, Voorhees, and the Army’s top generals, for example, insisted that a great deal could be done through defensive weaponry and counterpart funds.²⁰³

Nor were Soviet actions responsible for the threats that loomed so large in American eyes. Stalin was clamping down on Eastern Europe, brutally purging foes, and preparing another reign of terror within the Soviet Union itself. But these were not the matters that preoccupied U.S. officials. Policymakers in Washington focused on the dollar gap, the European integration impasse, and the task of co-opting German and Japanese power. These problems were not caused by Soviet behavior.²⁰⁴ Nor was the Soviet Union responsible for Mao's acquisition of power in China or Ho's popularity in Vietnam. Stalin's aid package to China and his recognition of the Viet Minh were neither daring nor bellicose actions, no matter how ominous they may have looked from Washington's perspective.

The problems that so perplexed and alarmed U.S. officials were not the making of the Soviet Union. But the very existence of the Soviet Union constituted a nightmare. Here was a totalitarian country with a revolutionary ideology that had great appeal to Third World peoples bent on throwing off Western rule and making rapid economic progress. Here was a totalitarian country whose domination of Eastern Europe and whose considerable influence in Northeast Asia gave it the potential to entice Germany and Japan into its orbit. Here was a totalitarian country whose developing atomic capabilities might inspire it to engage in risk-taking that it had heretofore avoided. If U.S. diplomacy were not active and vigilant, if U.S. aid were not forthcoming, and if U.S. determination were not evident to friends and foes alike, the industrial workshops of Europe and Asia and their attendant markets and raw materials could gravitate out of the U.S. orbit. The United States could become isolated in a hostile world. In such circumstances America's free and democratic system could not survive.²⁰⁵

All of this was perfectly familiar to policymakers. Hence NSC 68 provoked no great debate. It neither stirred deep emotions nor precipitated unusual controversy (except of a personal sort between Johnson and Acheson). It could not do so because it introduced no new goals and no new programs. It did not redefine the Soviet threat or claim that the Kremlin was ready to embark on outright aggression. Notwithstanding the dollar gap and the slump in the economy during 1949, it did not inject any new economic considerations into the discussion of U.S. diplomatic goals. In fact, it simply reaffirmed the geopolitical and ideological basis of U.S. foreign policy. Its major point was that Soviet atomic capabilities greatly intensified the Soviet threat by enhancing the Kremlin's penchant for risk-taking. In response, the United States had to enlarge its military capabilities if it were to fulfill its own objectives. But Nitze did not make a case for any particular level of military spending. He continued to regard military capabilities as most important for the shadows they cast, for their psychological repercussions, and for their influence on U.S. risk-taking rather than for warmaking. National security was still defined *not* in terms of numbers of troops, tanks, planes, and bombs, but in terms of control of industrial infrastructure, raw materials, and skilled labor.

NSC 68 might have made a useful contribution to policymaking had it boldly

confronted the question of limited war. Heretofore U.S. officials had concluded that thwarting Soviet influence in Greece, Turkey, and Iran was vital to U.S. security; they had stressed that containing communism in Southeast Asia was critical to holding Japan. Increasingly, they were claiming that the viability of South Korea and even Taiwan was essential to U.S. credibility in the world. Such language implied that, in the absence of global war, the United States (and its friends) should be willing to fight in diverse localities to thwart internal subversion or to stymie local aggression. But much ambiguity remained, generated by the knowledge that the United States did not have the forces to wage a limited war in these areas and be prepared to fight a global war at the same time.

In NSC 68 Nitze seemed to be saying that the United States had to be ready and able to utilize force in these local situations. Superior atomic forces would provide the necessary shield for it to engage in its own risk-taking. If the United States could maintain its overwhelming lead in strategic weaponry *and* if it could bolster conventional forces in Western Europe, the Kremlin's atomic arsenal and land power could be neutralized. The United States could then move ahead to accomplish its objectives through diplomatic, economic, and, if necessary, military initiatives in disparate localities around the globe.²⁰⁶ In fact, prospective neutralization of U.S. and Soviet atomic forces might make limited conventional or guerrilla wars the wave of the future.

Although the stress on limited war was an absolutely critical part of NSC 68, it was so buried in the long, rambling, and repetitive paper that it did not receive the attention it deserved. Ever since autumn 1945, U.S. military officials had wanted to know where, when, how, and in what circumstances the United States would employ force. In summer and autumn 1948, Forrestal had raised these matters stridently and forcefully. Yet in mid-1950, clear answers were still not forthcoming.

Had they been, it would have been too late anyway. North Korean forces were about to cross the 38th parallel.